



keeled scales on tail

alligators have a more rounded snout than crocodiles

American alligator

Alligator mississippiensis

This fearsome predator is restricted to wetlands and swamps of the southeastern US, and propels itself through water with its muscular, laterally flattened tail. On land, the American alligator can crawl on its underside or lift its body off the ground in a slow, waddling walk. If it draws its legs fully below its body, it can gallop for short distances, charging faster than many humans can run. Mostly a night hunter, it drifts or swims stealthily, then lunges at its prey.

Courtship and mating begin in April and May, with the males roaring and bellowing as low as they can to attract females. In August, 30–50 babies hatch in a nest mound of warm decomposing vegetation gathered by the mother. She listens for the hatching babies' chirps, helps them out of the nest, and carries them in her mouth down to the water. Size, power, and a thick skin mean an adult alligator has little to fear, but the young are vulnerable to predators and are protected by their mother for up to three years.

- ↔ 10–13 ft (3–4 m)
- ⚖ Up to 660 lb (300 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🐟 Fish, waterbirds, mammals
- 🏠 



SE. US

▷ POWERFUL JAWS

The alligator grabs its prey with about 80 conical teeth set in powerful jaws. A characteristic large tooth in the lower jaw fits into a socket in the upper jaw.



Common snapping turtle

Chelydra serpentina

Ranging as far north as Alberta, Canada, and as far south as the US Gulf Coast, some snapping turtles have even been seen in the Rocky Mountains—no mean feat for an animal that prefers to spend most of its time in muddy freshwater lakes and rivers.

As the name suggests, the snapping turtle bites. Highly aggressive on land, it is prone to snapping the heads off other turtles or taking a bite out of anything it comes across. The shells of older snapping turtles are usually covered in algae, enhancing their camouflage as they hide in wait for prey. Adults sometimes travel long distances overland and can end up as traffic fatalities, whereas hatchlings are vulnerable to attack by raccoons, herons, and skunks, as well as other turtles.



brown or olive to black upper shell



- ↔ 10–19 in (25–48 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 35 lb (16 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish, mammals, plants
- 🏠 



C. and E. USA

△ FEROCIOUS SNAPPER

Given their pugnacious temperament and tough carapace, adult “snappers” have few enemies and can live up to 40 years.